

Primary Source Reading 1: Man as a Political Animal

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From Aristotle, Politics, Book I, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 17a: Man as a Political Animal

Before you read: Aristotle has just argued that when villages unite into a single self-sufficient community, the state comes into being — and that because it is the natural end of the earlier, smaller communities, it is itself natural. From there he makes his most famous claim: that man is by nature a political animal. As you read, follow the argument about speech carefully — it is doing more work than it first appears.

The State Is a Creation of Nature

Hence it is evident that the state is a creation of nature, and that man is by nature a political animal. And he who by nature and not by mere accident is without a state, is either a bad man or above humanity... the natural outcast is forthwith a lover of war; he may be compared to an isolated piece at draughts.

Speech, Not Mere Voice

Now, that man is more of a political animal than bees or any other gregarious animals is evident. Nature, as we often say, makes nothing in vain, and man is the only animal whom she has endowed with the gift of speech. And whereas mere voice is but an indication of pleasure or pain, and is therefore found in other animals (for their nature attains to the perception of pleasure and pain and the intimation of them to one another, and no further), the power of speech is intended to set forth the expedient and inexpedient, and therefore likewise the just and the unjust. And it is a characteristic of man that he alone has any sense of good and evil, of just and unjust, and the like, and the association of living beings who have this sense makes a family and a state.

The State Is Prior to the Individual

Further, the state is by nature clearly prior to the family and to the individual, since the whole is of necessity prior to the part; for example, if the whole body be destroyed, there will be no foot or hand, except in an equivocal sense, as we might speak of a stone hand; for when destroyed the hand will be no better than that. But things are defined by their working and power; and we ought not to say that they are the same when they no longer have their proper quality, but only that they have the same name. The proof that the state is a creation of nature and prior to the individual is that the individual, when isolated, is not self-sufficing; and therefore he is like a part in relation to the whole.

Beast or God

But he who is unable to live in society, or who has no need because he is sufficient for himself, must be either a beast or a god: he is no part of a state. A social instinct is implanted in all men by nature, and yet he who first founded the state was the greatest of benefactors. For man, when perfected, is the best of animals, but, when separated from law and justice, he is the worst of all... But justice is the bond of men in states, for the administration of justice, which is the determination of what is just, is the principle of order in political society.

After you read: Notice that Aristotle's claim is not that isolated people are impossible, but that they are incomplete — like a hand cut off from a body, which is a hand “only in an equivocal sense.” As you read the lesson, compare this directly to Hobbes's isolated individual in the state of nature from last week. The two philosophers are not just disagreeing about facts; they disagree about what counts as a human being's natural, complete condition in the first place.